

If possible, refer to an external document or website that contains the full text of the license rather than including the entire lengthy license at the top of every source code file. It's tiring to have to scroll past several screen lengths of text whenever you open a source code file, and including the full license doesn't provide additional legal protection.

Professional Comments

At my first software job, a senior co-worker I greatly respected took me aside and explained that because we sometimes released our products' source code to clients, it was important that the comments maintain a professional tone. Apparently, I had written "WTF" in one of the comments for an especially frustrating part of the code. I felt embarrassed, immediately apologized, and edited the comment. Since that moment, I've kept my code, even for personal projects, at a certain level of professionalism.

You might be tempted to add levity or vent your frustrations in your program's comments, but make it a habit to avoid doing so. You don't know who will read your code in the future, and it's easy to misinterpret the tone of a text. As explained in "Avoid Jokes, Puns, and Cultural References" on page 64, the best policy is to write your comments in a polite, direct, and humorless tone.

Codetags and TODO Comments

Programmers sometimes leave short comments to remind themselves about work that remains to be done. This usually takes the form of a *codetag*: a comment with an all-uppercase label, such as `TODO`, followed by a short description. Ideally, you would use project management tools to track these sorts of issues rather than burying them deep in the source code. But for smaller, personal projects that aren't using such tools, the occasional `TODO` comment can serve as a helpful reminder. Here's an example:

```
_chargeIonFluxStream() # TODO: Investigate why this fails every Tuesday.
```

You can use a few different codetags for these reminders:

`TODO` Introduces a general reminder about work that needs to be done